though smaller corporations may not have the resources to do so. And wealthy individuals and unincorporated associations can spend unlimited amounts on independent expenditures. See, *e. g.*, *WRTL*, 551 U. S., at 503–504 (opinion of SCALIA, J.) ("In the 2004 election cycle, a mere 24 individuals contributed an astounding total of $142 million to [26 U. S. C. § 527 organizations]"). Yet certain disfavored associations of citizens—those that have taken on the corporate form—are penalized for engaging in the same political speech.

When Government seeks to use its full power, including the criminal law, to command where a person may get his or her information or what distrusted source he or she may not hear, it uses censorship to control thought. This is unlawful. The First Amendment confirms the freedom to think for ourselves.

2

What we have said also shows the invalidity of other arguments made by the Government. For the most part relinquishing the antidistortion rationale, the Government falls back on the argument that corporate political speech can be banned in order to prevent corruption or its appearance. In *Buckley*, the Court found this interest "sufficiently important" to allow limits on contributions but did not extend that reasoning to expenditure limits. 424 U. S., at 25. When *Buckley* examined an expenditure ban, it found "that the governmental interest in preventing corruption and the appearance of corruption [was] inadequate to justify [the ban] on independent expenditures." *Id.*, at 45.

With regard to large direct contributions, *Buckley* reasoned that they could be given "to secure a political *quid pro quo*," *id.*, at 26, and that "the scope of such pernicious practices can never be reliably ascertained," *id.*, at 27. The practices *Buckley* noted would be covered by bribery laws, see, *e. g.*, 18 U. S. C. § 201, if a *quid pro quo* arrangement were proved. See *Buckley*, *supra*, at 27, and n. 28 (citing *Buckley* v. *Valeo*, 519 F. 2d 821, 839–840, and nn. 36–38